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Addressing English teachers' concerns about decentering Standard English

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Decentering
Standard
English

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Abstract

Purpose – This paper aims to address concerns of English teachers considering opening up their classrooms to multiple varieties of English.

Design/methodology/approach – Drawing on the author's experience as a teacher educator and professional developer in different regions of the USA, this narrative paper groups teachers' concerns into general categories and offers responses to the most common questions.

Findings – Teachers want to know why they should make room in their classrooms for multiple Englishes; what they should teach differently; how they learn about English variation; how to balance Standardized English and other Englishes; and how these apply to English Learners and/or White speakers of Standardized English.

Practical implications – The study describes the author's approach to teaching about language as a way to promote social justice and equality, the value of increasing students' linguistic repertoires and why it is necessary to address listeners as well as speakers. As teachers attempt to adopt and adapt new approaches to teaching English language suggested in the research literature, they need to know their challenges and concerns are heard and addressed. Teacher educators working to support these teachers need ways to address teachers' concerns.

Social implications – This paper emphasizes the importance of teaching mainstream, White, Standard English-speaking students about English language variation. By emphasizing the role of the listener and teaching students to hear language through an expanded language repertoire, English teachers can reduce the prejudice attached to historically stigmatized dialects of English.

Originality/value – This paper provides a needed perspective on how to work with teachers who express legitimate concerns about what it means to decenter Standardized English in English classrooms.

Keywords English teaching, Literacy and identity, Critical language awareness, English dialects, English language variation

Paper type Conceptual paper

One recent spring afternoon, on the blossoming campus of a university in the Midwestern USA, faculty members in education engaged in earnest discussion of charged subject matter. One senior scholar, face reddening as the debate unfolded, finally exclaimed, "It makes me want to throw up!"

What were we discussing to arouse such disgust? Was it blatant plagiarism from a doctoral candidate? Failure of a cherished colleague to receive tenure? Budget cuts that would eliminate valued programming? No. We were discussing grammar and usage in student writing. In this particular case, we were discussing the Associated Press validating the use of *singular they* as a gender-neutral pronoun in their style guide. While the APA, MLA and CMS have not yet endorsed *singular they*, it is likely those changes are coming as well.



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For English teachers raised in a prescriptive grammar tradition – a tradition that promotes one “correct” form of English usage (Curzan, 2014) – changes such as these, which counter years of hard fought “error” correction, feel like betrayal. Many English teachers have taken on the role of language guardians, advocating the grammar of Standardized English[1] in students’ speech and upholding the writing conventions of historically sanctioned style guides.

Debates about standards for grammar and usage have existed since the first efforts at standardization (Wright, 2000), and these debates spill into English classrooms (take, for example, the heated and unresolved battle about the Oxford comma). In our current, polarized, political climate even grammar – the historically “objective” content of English language arts (ELA) classrooms – takes on heightened social and political meaning. As we witness a global rise in populist movements, demonstrated by the Brexit vote and the election of Donald Trump, along with a growing wave of xenophobia, the role of language in defining social insiders and outsiders carries significant weight. English teachers can play an important role in countering social prejudice by teaching about English language variation.

A growing body of sociolinguistic knowledge demonstrates connections between beliefs about language usage and social identities (Alim and Smitherman, 2012; Bucholtz and Hall, 2004; Eckert, 2000). The linguistic fact that all dialects and varieties of English are patterned, rule governed and linguistically equal, reveals that the concept of “correct” English is a language ideology, not a linguistic truth (Wolfram and Schilling, 2015). The emphasis on one version of English as “right” and others as “wrong” is based in social hierarchies rather than inherent characteristics of particular grammatical constructions (Lippi-Green, 2012). Increasing dissemination of these linguistic facts has begun to weaken the reliance on romanticized tradition in how English norms are taught.

Since I stepped out of the classroom after 15 years of teaching, I’ve worked extensively with new and veteran teachers exploring the relationship between language, culture and power in English classrooms. While most teachers I work with support the idea of valuing students’ cultural ways of being, they often balk at decentering Standardized English. By decentering, I mean removing Standardized English as the central focus of language teaching, and instead, including Standardized English as one, among many, Englishes at the heart of language study.

The reluctance on the part of many English teachers to embrace the English varieties their students bring to the classroom stands in contrast to the way these very English teachers embrace other aspects of cultural pluralism. I’ve worked with English teachers who eagerly adopt multicultural texts reflective of the students they serve, use young adult literature to engage students as active readers and develop students’ literary analysis skills through the integration of multi-modal texts; yet these very teachers hold tightly to grammar instruction that marginalizes and stigmatizes all Englishes other than Standardized English.

Perhaps more than any other content area, ELA teachers experience the importance of the relationship between students’ identity and the subject matter being taught. We know that students need to see themselves in the texts we study (Landt, 2006). We know that they need opportunities to express their own understandings and life experiences as they develop their skill as writers (Martin, 2003). Yet, we have been slow to take up the inclusion of diverse English varieties as legitimate content in our study of the English language (Mallinson and Charity Hudley, 2013). Over a decade ago, this journal devoted two complete issues to the theme “Knowledge about language in the English/literacy classroom” (Locke, 2005, 2006) yet progress incorporating those ideas plods tediously. How do we account for

the slow pace of change in the way language is taught? My experience working with pre-service and in-service teachers in various contexts across the USA shows that teachers express similar, valid concerns as they wrestle with the idea of decentering Standardized English.

In the remainder of this article, I make the case for embracing multiple Englishes and teaching English language variation by addressing the thoughtful questions of concerned teachers and administrators I've worked with over the years. My hope is that by highlighting the political nature of choices to teach about English, and the resulting social consequences, English teachers will consider the impact of teaching English "as they were taught" and work toward integrating more linguistic research into their teaching and talk about language.

What's the point?

"Is justice the point of literacy? Are we supposed to build equality through our language? I'm not sure I agree with that." (A veteran English teacher)

During a recent course I taught, a veteran teacher asked the above question on a discussion board in response to readings about language, culture and power. The question reveals that some reluctance to teach about language variation goes back to beliefs about the fundamental purposes of schooling. There are many English teachers who view language diversity as a problem (Curzan, 2014; Hancock and Kolln, 2010). These English teachers aspire to create a common culture that promotes national unity. This common culture takes the form of a monolingual, mono-cultural society predicated on White middle-class norms. This set of beliefs aligns with traditionally conservative views of what it means to be American, and what knowledge should be taught in schools to preserve American culture (Hirsch, 1988; Provenzo, 2006). For these teachers, Standardized English is a vehicle to create this national unity. The teacher quoted above sees her role as an English teacher as helping her students in gaining access to this national culture through language. I strive to help these teachers unpack that understanding.

It is important that this teacher invoked the principles of justice and equality in her question because historical efforts to promote a narrow view of national identity have led to unjust and unequal treatment of many Americans. Americans who experience injustice and inequality based on Standardized English ideologies in schooling practices are those who experience discrimination in other aspects of society based on their skin color, cultural practices and linguistic background (Alim *et al.*, 2016; Hartman, 2003; Lash, 2017). Continuing to teach English the way we always have perpetuates this injustice and inequality for many Americans.

To this teacher and others who may wonder if we must politicize our teaching of language and literacy I reply, "What is the alternative?" If the point of literacy is not justice, what is it? If we are not building equality through teaching language, what are we building? None of the teachers I've worked with over the years would advocate injustice. That is not their goal. None want to hurt children. Teachers do what they think is best for their students. But they often view literacy and language as neutral; standing outside of issues of justice and equality. And that view is not sustainable in the middle of the twenty-first century, in increasingly multicultural and multilingual societies, in a time where speakers of world Englishes out-number speakers of American English (Canagarajah, 2006). Holding onto a romanticized and inaccurate view of a single correct, and unchanging, English, that follows uniform, rigid and persistent rules is not a neutral stance but rather a strongly ideological set of beliefs that is ultimately political in nature.

As many before me have explained much more eloquently than I can (Appleman, 2015; Cochran-Smith, 2010), there is no neutral position in teaching. Even support of the status quo involves taking a position. The status quo for teaching about language in ELA classrooms positions students who speak historically stigmatized language varieties as deficient, uneducated and even immoral. (In their text for teachers, Dunn and Lindblom (2011) powerfully demonstrate and critique the societal link between language and morality through an analysis of “grammar rants”.) Continuing this practice contradicts established research in linguistics and promotes injustice and inequality.

I am transparent about subscribing to a view of schooling, which embraces our pluralistic society and values the diversity of languages, cultures and knowledge traditions represented by the heritage cultures in our immigrant nation, as well as the continually evolving hybrid cultural practices that result from the intermingling of those traditions. From my point of view, this plurality is the strength of the USA. I show teachers examples of people – Barak Obama being a prime example (Alim and Smitherman, 2012) – who employ varied linguistic resources to move fluidly through wide-ranging cultural communities. A goal of schooling should be to help students expand their repertoires of linguistic and cultural ways of being so that they can communicate comfortably across contexts. The goal of schooling is to give students more options, not fewer. Expanding the number of Englishes taught in school allows students to access mainstream culture if they choose, while validating and supporting the diverse cultures that make up the USA and other countries in our increasingly intermixed global society.

What do I teach?

“So, you’re saying that when it comes to grammar and writing, anything goes?”

“If I can’t correct their mistakes, then I should just let them go?”

Once teachers accept the validity of multiple Englishes, they often feel stuck. I get questions like the two above from teachers at a summer institute I led in the San Francisco Bay Area. These are valid questions that represent honest struggle with changing a long-held belief about what counts as correct English, and the English teacher’s role in supporting it.

Error correction, in speech and writing, remains a staple of ELA classrooms (Shaughnessy, 1979; Smith and Wilhelm, 2007). When I ask teachers to stop thinking in terms of “errors” and “correction”, they’re not sure what to do instead. Many teachers express frustration through questions similar to the one above, “If I can’t correct their mistakes, then I should just let them go?” I tell these teachers there is a third option.

First, I emphasize getting rid of the terms “error” and “mistake”. Unless we are talking about a typo (which is an error and a mistake), the errors and mistakes teachers usually identify are not errors at all. They are alternative grammatical constructions or stylistic options that come from Englishes or registers different than what the teacher expects or accepts (Reaser *et al.*, 2017). Using an alternative, and equally valid, language variety is a fundamentally different concept than making an error. Because they are not *errors*, they do not need to be, and should not be, *corrected*. That does not mean that students’ grammatical usage should not be addressed.

Identifying features of different Englishes in students’ writing creates opportunities to teach students about the English language (Chisholm and Godley, 2011; McBee Orzulak, 2013). Take, for example, the two variations of the sentence below.

- (1) Ashley sing in the car.
- (2) Ashley sings in the car.

Sentence (1) follows a rule in African–American English that regularizes verb forms by not marking third-person singular verbs with an “s”. Linguist John Rickford describes the grammar rule this way, “Thou shalt not treat present-tense verbs with third-person-singular subjects any differently from verbs with other subjects” (Rickford and Rickford, 2000, p. 112). This feature is increasingly used by a wide range of young people in urban schools in America (Paris, 2011). In Standardized English, the third-person singular requires an “s”, thus a Standardized English user would follow the pattern in sentence (2). Neither sentence is right or wrong. Each follows a clear grammatical rule. Even so, teachers, for generations, have “corrected” students “errors” like this in subject-verb agreement. Rather than inaccurately “correcting” students, a more precise and productive approach would be to for teachers to describe the different grammatical rules regarding subject-verb agreement. Teachers can then explain when and why they expect students to follow each set of rules.

The alternative to “correcting” is not “anything goes”. The alternative to correcting is *teaching* students accurate grammatical information that validates the patterned, rule-bound nature of all dialects of English. Of course, few teachers have been taught this information themselves, which puts them in a tough position.

What do I need to know?

“But I don’t have the language knowledge to pick out these moments and build on them. Are you saying I need to go back to school to study linguistics?”

Many of the teachers I work with have fantastic content knowledge when it comes to literature, writing and even Standardized English grammar, but few have much knowledge of English language variation. Even fewer have studied sociolinguistics or linguistic variation in ways that would prepare them to recognize and describe features of the many varieties of English they will encounter in their classrooms. Clearly, schools of education need to dedicate more time and attention to English language variation in teacher preparation courses. At the same time, holding teachers responsible for knowledge they were never exposed to is counterproductive. We can neither ask all English teachers to pick up degrees in linguistics nor should we. We can, however, provide teachers with some guiding principles and resources to help them navigate and learn as they wrestle productively with multiple Englishes over the course of their careers.

The primary principle I ask teachers to adopt is that there are no errors in students’ language use. By its very nature, language is patterned and rule governed. Our job as teachers of the English language is to help identify and describe the patterns we encounter. When a distinct term, phrase, pronunciation or grammatical construction stands out as being “marked” in some way, it presents an opportunity to learn something new about how language works. I can do the investigation myself, or I can invite students to investigate with me. Thanks to the wonderful community of sociolinguists and others studying language variation, resources abound. (I’ve compiled a growing resource list on my website: www.metzteaching.com/resources-for-teachers.html.)

An example helps illustrate what this process might look like. The majority of students I taught during my 15 years as a public-school teacher in Chicago spoke a variety of African American English. One colleague of mine, a fellow English teacher, was very particular about making sure students pronounced the word *ask* with the “k” sound at the end. When students pronounced the word with the k sound in the middle (*aks* or *ax*), she would correct them. The demeaning tone she would use, and the way she described the alternative pronunciation as “wrong” or even “ignorant”, troubled me. I didn’t have the knowledge to describe the linguistic process at play, and wasn’t able to articulate what bothered me about her approach, so I did some digging.

A Google search of “ask aks” returned over five hundred thousand results, but the top hit was a very accessible newspaper article from the LA times that lays out the historical and social journey of the word, with an eye to the impact of language on identity (McWhorter, 2014). Further research gave more detail. (*Spoken Soul* by Rickford and Rickford is an accessible explanation of Black English, while *American English: Dialects and Variation* by Wolfram & Schilling is a comprehensive tome.) It turns out that the inversion of the consonant sounds in a word is part of a linguistic process called metathesis. It is common in many words, but *ask* vs *aks* is one of the most socially marked forms. I learned that Shakespeare used both forms in his plays. There is debate about whether aks or ask is the original form and which version is the changed form. I found out that the same principle is at play in pronunciation of nuclear as “nu-**cu**-lar” and comfortable as “comf-**ter**-ble.” However, these examples are not socially marked in the same way as *ask* and *aks*.

As I read more, I learned that the reason certain features get stigmatized has less to do with language and more to do with the social identity of the speakers (Lippi-Green, 2012). As educational linguist Jonathan Rosa recently remarked, “In reality, we are often not correcting students’ language. We are correcting their identity. We are correcting their race” (Rosa, 2017). The use of *ax* is as much about signaling racial identity as it is communicating other content.

I didn’t know any of this when my colleague corrected our high school students years ago. I did not need to take a linguistics class to learn it. When I started with the assumption that my students were correct, but applying a different rule, I was able to find out aspects of the rule with minimal investigation. And now I know. Like anything else in teaching, I encourage teachers not to let their current knowledge limit what they teach their students. Learn with them!

What about the real world?

“My students need to learn Standard English for tests and job interviews.”

“What about the Delpit question?”

One day, after I delivered a research talk about teaching critical language awareness at Stanford University, a prominent professor asked pointedly, “What about the Delpit question?” By “the Delpit question”, this professor referred to the issue raised in Lisa Delpit’s much cited article “The Silenced Dialogue” (Delpit, 1988). In this article, Delpit interrogates an approach to language teaching summed up by the statement: “Children have the right to their own language, their own culture. We must fight cultural hegemony and fight the system by insisting that children be allowed to express themselves in their own language style. It is not they, the children, who must change, but the schools. To push children to do anything else is repressive and reactionary” (p. 291). Delpit critiques, not this belief, but the teaching (or lack of teaching) she observed in response to this belief. For Delpit, it is important that students who are not born into the culture of power are explicitly taught the codes of power. She saw teachers using the belief in students’ right to their own language as a tool to avoid taking responsibility for teaching students the codes of Standardized English that are necessary cultural currency in mainstream America.

When the professor asked me to respond to “the Delpit question”, he wanted to know how I address the tension inherent in asking teachers to teach the language of power, while also asking them, “to fight cultural hegemony and fight the system by insisting that children be allowed to express themselves in their own language style”.

I respond to this question in two ways. First, I clarify that this is not a case of “either or [...]” but a case of “Yes, and [...]”. I advocate a repertoire approach that seeks to increase

the size of students' linguistic repertoires – students' linguistic toolkits (Orellana *et al.*, 2010). Students need to acquire Standardized English forms and features, while holding onto the linguistic styles of their home and community. The more dialects and registers of English they can incorporate into their repertoires the more power they have.

Second, I trouble the notion that Standardized English is the language of power. Increasingly, monolingual speakers who only have access to Standardized English dialects are limited in their linguistic power. The new language of power is a language of flexibility and dexterity (Alim and Smitherman, 2012; Young *et al.*, 2013; Canagarajah, 2017). It accounts for the complexity of identities expressed through language. When teachers need concrete examples, I show them Marc Lamont Hill. When Dr Hill speaks to large and multifaceted audiences he moves fluidly between registers and dialects. He will quote Foucault's "insurrection of subjugated knowledges" in one breath, then in the next breath invoke contemporary hip-hop culture or drop references to the black church. He uses a range of linguistic codes to signal multiple aspects of his identity while meeting the diverse expectations of complex audiences. His extensive linguistic repertoire gives him power he would not have if he only spoke an academic register of Standardized English.

Delpit advocates teaching students the rules to the game of political and social power. In the 20 years since her article was written, the rules of that game have evolved. Political power in our society comes not from Standardized English, but from Standardized English meshed with other language varieties (Young *et al.*, 2013). This is as true for students as for presidents (Alim and Smitherman, 2012).

We also need to be careful that we do not oversell students on the power of Standardized English. While it is an invaluable tool to include in their linguistic toolkits, it does not erase other forms of discrimination and prejudice (Flores and Rosa, 2015). Yes, our students need to be prepared to meet the linguistic expectations of test-makers and gate-keepers so that they can succeed in the political game if they desire. They also need to be able to recognize that the game is rigged to favor Standardized English. Teaching students the validity of multiple English varieties can help them change the rules of the game (Godley and Loretto, 2013).

What about my ELs?

"My students are ELs. Teaching them different Englishes will just confuse them."

While much of my work with teachers focuses on dialects of English, the linguistically complex classrooms many teachers serve necessitate an even wider vision of language. As teachers weigh the benefits of teaching English language in ways that validate language variation I've had many express reservations on behalf of students learning English as a second or additional language. These students have needs that are distinct from students who speak dialects of English. The concern teachers express in relation to their school designated English Learners (ELs) often parallels concerns addressed above: ELs need Standardized English to be successful on standardized tests and to enter the professional world of work and school. My response to this concern is the same as described above. Yes, and[. . .] Take a repertoire approach.

When teachers suggest that their EL students will be confused if teachers validate multiple Englishes, I ask them to consider how students will make sense of the linguistic landscape if they only learn Standardized English. The world is made up of multiple Englishes. American English is just one version of the many world Englishes. International students often have exposure to other world Englishes in addition to the dialects of American English (Canagarajah, 2006). As our ELs will experience multiple Englishes, it only makes sense to help them navigate those Englishes in ways that acknowledge the social meanings attached to different dialects. ELs, just like native English speakers, are

better served by language teaching that accurately describes the way Englishes work in society, including the facts of various valid grammars, and the social prestige and stigma attached to the linguistically equal forms. ELs need to be able to understand multiple Englishes, as well as produce those Englishes to adeptly navigate American society.

The political and social histories of English in countries outside the USA give dialects of English in those contexts unique social meaning. Whatever the context, as students learn English as an additional language, they are best served by being taught that dialects followed patterned rules and are linguistically equal, *and* that different dialects serve as social markers within social and cultural groups.

What about my white students?

“My students are all white, so this doesn’t really apply to my context.”

“My students speak Standard English already. I don’t need to talk about this with them.”

When I worked on the south side of Chicago, English variation was clearly racialized as a Black–White issue. In the schools I studied in California, students’ Englishes reflected a wide range of internationally influenced linguistic backgrounds: Spanish-influenced English, Mandarin-influenced English, Tagalog-influenced English, etc. The literature on language variation in schools often focuses on “urban” contexts, and suggests that teaching about language variation is best suited for students who speak historically stigmatized language varieties (Alim and Baugh, 2007; Ball *et al.*, 2011; Paris, 2011). The goal in these cases is to help teachers and students find the value in the English varieties students bring to the classroom. The ultimate aim is to increase the engagement and attachment to school for students who have historically been marginalized, leading to successful school outcomes. But that goal is too limited. Knowledge of English language variation is not just for urban kids of color.

The election of Donald Trump in the USA has been seen by many as a backlash by White America against attention and resources devoted to a multi-cultural and urban population (Kellner, 2017). While the implications of Trump’s election just begin to play out, one result has been increased efforts to understand rural and white America. This makes it a particularly fruitful time to bring studies of language variation out of diverse urban contexts and into more homogeneous white spaces. Recently, I’ve begun work with English teachers in predominantly white contexts, both rural and suburban. In both spaces, the importance of teaching about English language variation has been clear.

In rural White contexts in the USA, teachers describe the same issues of language stigmatization that teachers describe on the south side of Chicago. They often view students coming to school with “poor language skills” speaking “bad English”. As a teacher in my course wrote on a discussion post, “One of my students has a very, what you call “redneck” accent, very low reading scores, needs constant support and rarely utters a sentence that is grammatically correct”. In rural white contexts, the social stigmatization tied to language use highlights class over race. It is often associated with the education level of particular families or geographic areas. Still, the principles tying together language, culture and power are the same. There is extensive research on southern English, and there are increasingly nuanced descriptions of the Englishes of distinct rural communities. (For teaching materials related to Southern English, see for example, Charity Hudley and Mallinson, 2010; Reaser and Wolfram, 2007). Many of the students in these communities have felt alienated from school because of the variety of English they speak in similar ways to the alienation felt by urban students of color.

In contrast to the way work on language variation in schools has traditionally been framed, it is becoming increasingly clear to me that White suburban students who speak Standardized English need to be taught about language variation more than almost any other group. A prominent current book on language variation in schools, *Dialects at School* (Reaser *et al.*, 2017) has the subtitle “Educating Linguistically Diverse Students”. While it is important that we educate “linguistically diverse students”, it is even more important that we educate mainstream, white, monolingual students about the validity of English varieties in the world around them. For these students, the goal is not improved schooling outcomes. Standardized tests, school funding systems and even textbooks are already designed to cater to this demographic. Rather than focusing on improved school outcomes, teaching these students about English variation would result in improved social outcomes.

The goal of teaching White middle-class, mainstream students about language variation is to help them understand language differently, to hear differently, to question and critique the stigma associated with marginalized Englishes. A shift from focusing on the *speaker* to focusing on the *listener* (Flores and Rosa, 2015) completely changes the dynamics of how we think about teaching dialects in school. Teaching white middle-class *listeners* to *hear* differently, to be aware of the discriminatory *listening practices* of mainstream society, is a step toward making significant social change. While past practices have emphasized teaching speakers and writers to produce language using a range of linguistic conventions, moving forward, English teachers should also emphasize teaching listeners and readers to consume a range of Englishes with the intention of understanding rather than judging.

The shared responsibility for understanding between the speaker and listener has been called the communicative burden (Lippi-Green, 2012). The approach to dialects in school to this point has placed an inordinate share of the communicative burden on speakers; hence, the focus on “educating linguistically diverse students”. To distribute the communicative burden more equally, we need to focus on “educating linguistically homogenous students”. We need to increase the linguistic repertoires of students who are constrained by a Standardized English mode of *hearing/listening*.

If, as I advocated earlier, the goal of literacy is justice, and we are using language teaching to work for social equality, then the students who benefit most from the current system need to learn that they’ve been taught half-truths that help them and harm others. The more that we teach White middle-class students the validity of other Englishes, particularly when those students otherwise would have limited exposure to those Englishes, the more we reduce the potential of future discrimination.

What else?

There are many more questions and concerns raised by the teachers I’ve worked with: White teachers often feel uncomfortable teaching and talking about African–American English. Black teachers are sometimes the harshest critics of African–American English. Parents raise a range of concerns. Members of English departments don’t see eye-to-eye. Administrators need convincing. And then there are always the standardized tests that assume, incorrectly, the grammar of Standardized English is the only English grammar.

So we arrive back at the question of politics. If every stance we take as teachers is a political stance, then let’s adopt a stance that’s aligned with accurate linguistic knowledge. Let’s adopt a stance that’s expands students’ linguistic repertoires. Let’s use language knowledge, in the same way we use literature and writing, to help our students learn more about themselves and the world around them. Let’s describe the grammar our students use and encounter in the world instead of trying to prescribe the grammar they should use. Let’s help students consider how different language choices are read by different audiences in

different contexts. Let's help them match their language use to their purposes, including the purpose of conveying their identity in ways that feel genuine.

Our job as English teachers is to teach students about language as it really works in the world. This means teaching them that language is a gatekeeping tool used to exclude certain kinds of people from positions of power. It also means teaching them that all languages are valid, valuable and vivacious. We can teach our students to play the game of Standardized English, at the same time that we challenge policy makers to deepen their knowledge of Englishes. Understanding how language is used in political ways to shape (and perpetuate) social hierarchies should be taught alongside the (various) rules of subject-verb agreement. To return to the anecdote that began this essay, adopting "singular they" is not an abandonment of principles, but a lesson in how language works. Discussing "singular they" with students allows for understanding of how gendered language shapes our experience of the world, as well as demonstrating important and ongoing processes of language change.

By taking an inquiry stance toward language, by opening up the meaning of language use instead of focusing on one narrow form, we make space for our students to enter the English classroom as powerful contributors to our collective language knowledge. In our current political climate that sees renewed calls for nationalism, increased xenophobia and an emphasis on overly simple solutions to complex problems, promoting a nuanced and accurate view of language and identity is a hard sell. A clear-cut, restricted view of what counts as "correct" language is a much easier way to approach English teaching. But it is short-sighted and inaccurate. As the experts in our subject area, English teachers have a responsibility to acquire precise linguistic knowledge based in facts, not romanticized myths. We have a responsibility to hold up truths about language even when the political climate makes it unpopular. As English teachers, we can use our content area to demonstrate that there are many ways to be correct. Through the study of English dialects, we can demonstrate that when we pool our knowledge we are better off than when we divide it. By taking a repertoire approach to language knowledge, we model the power of a pluralistic society and take a stand against xenophobia and other forms of prejudice. That's a political act.

Note

1. I use the term Standardized English in place of Standard English to highlight that standardization is an active social process, not an inherent characteristic of any particular variety of English.

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